

Session 23: Reflecting on Jonah's Flight

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is the most extreme example of a prophet who resists God's call on their life.
- God wants humans to experience Eden, but they keep forfeiting it through rebellion and creating their own versions of it. Cain's city, Babylon, and Jerusalem under Israel's kings all represent false Edens.
- [Psalm 139](#) is a good companion text for Jonah because Jonah was clearly on the mind of the psalmist.
- The authors of the Hebrew Bible are mostly anonymous because what matters to the text's authority are the people in whom the tradition is anchored such as Moses, the prophets, or Isaiah.

The Resistant Prophet

Jonah's flight is extreme behavior for a resistant prophet, bringing to mind other resistant prophets in the Hebrew Bible, like Moses, Elijah, and Jeremiah. This action by Jonah opens up large-scale comparisons and contrasts with these three prophets.

Moses the Resistant Prophet

Exodus 3:10 NASB

Therefore, come now, and I will send you to Pharaoh, so that you may bring my people, the sons of Israel, out of Egypt.

The commission

Exodus 3:11 NASB

Who am I?

First objection

Exodus 3:13 NASB

What is [your] name?

Second objection: Moses is asking, "Who are you?"

Exodus 4:1 NASB

What if they [don't] believe me?

Third objection

Exodus 4:10 NASB*

Please, my Lord, I'm not a man of words ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Fourth objection

Exodus 4:13 ESV*

Please, my Lord, send someone else!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Fifth objection

Exodus 4:12 NASB

Now then go, and I, even I, will be with your mouth, and teach you what you are to say.

God's response

Jeremiah the Slightly Less Resistant Prophet

Jeremiah 1:4-5 NASB

⁴ Now the word of the LORD came to me saying,

⁵ "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you,
and before you were born I consecrated you;
I have appointed you a prophet to the nations."

The commission

Jeremiah 1:6a NIV*

Look, I don't know how to speak!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

First objection

Jeremiah 1:6b NIV

I am too young!

Second objection

Jeremiah 1:7-9 NASB

⁷ “Do not say, ‘I am too young,’ because everywhere I send you, you shall go.

⁸ And all that I command you, you shall speak ...”

⁹ Then the LORD stretched out his hand and touched my mouth, and the LORD said to me, “Behold, I have put my words in your mouth.”

God’s response

Elijah the Disillusioned Death-Wish Prophet

1 Kings 17:1-2 NASB

¹ Now Elijah the Tishbite, was of the settlers of Gilead ... ² The word of the LORD came to him ...

The commission

1 Kings 19:1-4 NASB

¹ Now Ahab told Jezebel all that Elijah had done, and how he had killed all the prophets with the sword. ² Then Jezebel sent a messenger to Elijah, saying, “So may the gods do to me and even more, if I do not make your life as the life of one of them by tomorrow about this time.” ³ And he was afraid and arose and ran for his life and came to Beersheba, which belongs to Judah, and left his servant there. ⁴ But he himself went a day’s journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a juniper tree; and he requested his life, that he might die, and said, “It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life, for I am not better than my fathers.”

After his unsuccessful mission on Mount Carmel

Jonah the Utterly Rebellious Prophet

Jonah 4:3, 8 NASB*

³ “Take my life, for better is my death than my life!” ... ⁸ And he requested his his life to die,

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

After his successful mission in Nineveh

Jonah is an extreme character among the prophets, taking the motif of the resistant prophet to the next level. He is more resistant to his call than Moses or Jeremiah, and he is more comic than Elijah in that he too wants to die, but only after an outstanding success in his prophetic calling.

Reflection Question

How is Jonah like Moses or Jeremiah?